



# Editorial style guide

January 2023

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FOR INTERNAL USE ONLY

# About this guide

As an international organization, KPMG speaks to a global audience and shares content across a global network of member firms. With this in mind, this guide establishes global standards using the Associated Press Stylebook and Merriam Webster dictionary as the basis for our editorial style. If there is an item not referenced in this guidance, please use AP or Merriam-Webster as your default.

## Language

To be consistent while maximizing reach, we use one language — US English — for most publications. By using US English, your content will likely get greater exposure.

National communications may use languages other than US English. Please contact your brand manager and communication team for details on the approved local style.

# Editorial style

## Abbreviations

For the sake of clarity, we generally do not use abbreviations, except:

1. when using social titles (e.g. Mr., Ms., etc.)
2. to express dates, times and numbers (e.g. 9 a.m. to 7 p.m., 8:30 a.m. to midday, etc.). Use “No.” with numbers to identify an item in a sequence or an item with a given number, albeit not as a substitute for the word number (e.g. “She works in room No. 7”).

## Academic degrees

Use an apostrophe in “bachelor’s degree” and “master’s degree.” Don’t capitalize the names of degrees.

Avoid the use of academic degrees or titles in international documents unless they are needed to establish someone’s credentials or readers will recognize the qualification.

## Accents

Use accents when you need to ensure words can be read, understood, or spoken accurately (e.g. cliché). Any foreign word in a formal title must have all of its accents.

## Acronyms

Always use capital letters in acronyms, but avoid periods (e.g. BPS, USA, FAQ, etc.). To make an acronym plural, simply add a lowercase “s” (e.g. FAQ becomes FAQs).

## Ampersands

Use an ampersand when it is part of the formal name of an organization, division or other entity.

Use an ampersand for KPMG services and industries:

- Information, Communications & Entertainment
- Transactions & Restructuring

In general, don’t use “&” in place of “and,” including when writing generally about industries and services:

- she was an expert in mergers and acquisitions, not “mergers & acquisitions”

## Apostrophes

1. Use apostrophes to indicate possession:
  - The regulator’s opinion = the opinion of the regulator
  - The regulators’ opinions = the opinions of the regulators
  - The company’s challenge = the challenge belonging to the company
  - The companies’ challenges = the challenges belonging to the companies

2. Use apostrophes to indicate omission of letters or numbers:

- summer of '45 = 1945
- I love the music of the '80s = 1980s
- can't = cannot
- he's = he is or he has

3. Use apostrophes to form special plurals:

- this is a list of best practice how-to's
- always dot the i's and cross the t's

But don't use apostrophes to form plurals of numbers or multiple letter combinations. Instead, simply add an "s":

- look in the FAQs
- the airline has five new 747s

### Bullet points

Use bullet points to emphasize a series of three or more items. When the bullet point list contains single words or short phrases, begin each with a lowercase letter.

The firm needs:

- up-to-date information
- a high level of security
- cost savings

When each bullet point is a complete sentence, begin it with a capital letter and end with appropriate punctuation. For example:

Ask yourself how the following key issues are affecting the business:

- How can we obtain up-to-date information?
- Is our security good enough?
- How can we achieve cost savings?

### Capitalization

Avoid unnecessary capital letters and be careful if setting type in all caps, which is the written equivalent of shouting.

As a rule, do not capitalize:

- a.m. and p.m.
- the firm
- environmental, social and governance (ESG)
- net zero
- the company
- web
- intranet
- internet
- metaverse
- government
- the board

Do use capital letters to indicate:

- the first word in a sentence
- proper nouns

Do capitalize nouns that constitute the unique identification of a specific person, place or object:

- I visited Grandma
- I visited my grandma
- I like Uncle Brian
- my uncle is a nice man

Capitalize common nouns when they are an integral part of the full name for a person, place or thing:

- The Federal Government
- Swan River
- St. James Street

Use lowercase for common nouns when they stand alone in subsequent references:

- the state government
- the river
- the street

Use lowercase for the common noun elements of names in all plural uses:

- the Republican and Democrat parties
- St. James and Main streets

Capitalize days of the week, months and holidays, but not seasons:

- It was a wet Monday in July, but people were dressed for a hot summer's day.

Capitalize words that are derived from a proper noun and still depend on it for their meaning:

- English
- Shakespearean
- Marxism

## Principles for capitalizing titles

### *Composition titles*

KPMG's style is sentence case, however, apply the following guidelines to titles of books, movies, operas, plays, poems, songs, television programs, lectures, speeches and works of art. In addition, italicize the names of entire published works, including books, periodicals, plays, reports, events and awards.

Capitalize principal words only:

- *The Catcher in the Rye*
- *The European Commercial Vehicle Industry in the Age of Globalization*

Capitalize all words in a title except articles (a, an, the); prepositions of three or fewer letters (for, of, on, up, etc.); and conjunctions of three or fewer letters (and, but, for, nor, or, so, yet, etc.) unless any of those start or end the title.

- *An Inconvenient Truth*
- *The Art of War*

### *Job titles*

Capitalize formal titles when used directly before an individual's name and the title is not separated by commas:

- Senior Manager Virginia Collins took over the work.
- A senior manager, Virginia Collins, took over the work.
- Virginia Collins, senior manager, took over the work.

## Company names

Company names should be written in the form the company uses and should be referred to in the singular form:

- Ford manufactures cars, and its name is known throughout the world.
- IT Services has introduced new guidelines.
- KPMG has 4,000 employees. It is currently recruiting nationally.

## Divisions of KPMG

The names of KPMG divisions, functions and business units should be capitalized, but the words “division,” “group” or “practice” should be written in lowercase:

- Corporate Finance practice
- Capital Markets group

## Colons

Use a colon at the end of a sentence to introduce a list, quotation, dialogue or question. Only capitalize the first word after a colon if it is the beginning of a complete sentence, the beginning of a quote, or a proper noun (e.g. the name of a specific person, place or object). Otherwise, use lowercase. For example:

- The proposal called for three sections: background, audit procedures and conclusion.
- James Wilson: This proposal is not complete.
- The question is this: Who will complete the proposal?

You can also use colons to begin a series of bullet points. For example:

The following factors will be taken into consideration:

- age
- education
- experience

## Commas

When used correctly, commas help your reader understand what you mean, though too many can lead to confusion and interrupt flow. Here are some general guidelines:

1. Use commas to separate items in a series. In general, avoid commas before “and” and “or” (i.e. Oxford commas):
  - His responsibilities include training, employee education, planning and assessments.
  - She collected the fees, taxes and interest payments.
2. Use commas before “and” and “or” only in instances where it adds clarity or if your sentence has a complex series of phrases that would benefit from separation:
  - We thank our colleagues, the President, and the students.
  - The main points to consider are whether the companies are stable enough to compete, whether they have the stamina to endure the economic downturn, and whether they have the proper structures.
3. Use commas to join two statements:
  - Almost everyone knows how they might spend a fortune, but few are able to make one.
4. Use commas to convey critical information:
  - All new employees, who are due to join the firm on 1 June, will attend an introductory course for one week.

### TIP

**If a series of phrases already contains commas, you can use semicolons to distinguish items:**

- The meeting was attended by Pieter Ward, chairman of the board; Margaret Davies, chief operating officer; and Carla Cuppini, company spokesperson.



## 5. Additional examples:

To highlight contrast:

- The more you work, the less you accomplish.

To address people:

- The goal of the project, ladies and gentlemen, is to make a profit.

To present examples:

- Some engagements, for instance those in the banking sector, are particularly sought after.

To introduce a title:

- John Simmons, director of travel, made the arrangements.

To pause after a salutation:

- Dear Tom, thank you for your attendance.

To add non-essential information:

- Unlike the insurance client list, the list of banking clients was alphabetized.

To separate identical or similar words:

- Whatever you do, do it well.

To help express “if ... then” statements:

- If he chooses, then the consultant can work abroad.

## Contractions

We use contractions like “can’t” and “they’re” in everyday speech and to give writing a friendly, personable tone. To reinforce our *clear* tone of voice, contractions can be used to help reinforce a more conversational tone. The key is to be consistent. For example, don’t use both “he is” and “he’s” in the same document. Use an apostrophe in contractions to indicate that some letters or numbers have been left out:

- can’t (cannot)
- he’s (he is or he has)

**Note:** KPIs, CEOs, FAQs, dos, don’ts, etc., are not contractions, but plurals, and therefore don’t have apostrophes.

## Countries

You can use an abbreviated name if it’s immediately recognizable to your reader or if you have introduced the abbreviation in brackets earlier. Do not use full stops (periods) between letters:

- Companies in the UK and the United Arab Emirates (UAE) are involved.
- The European Union (EU) is growing fast, creating exciting new career opportunities for many EU citizens.

Remember to refer to places by their exact status and be careful about using apparently equivalent names for countries and areas — sometimes there are significant differences in meaning and usage. Failure to fully understand the geopolitical landscape can have a fundamental impact on an organization’s brand and ability to operate. Please consult the [Marketing and Communications Geopolitical protocol](#) to ensure appropriate references. Here are some examples:

- The Hong Kong Special Administrative Region is not a country or region, but rather a local area within China.
- Great Britain consists of England, Scotland and Wales; the United Kingdom also includes Northern Ireland.
- Holland refers to just two of the 11 provinces of the Netherlands. Use the Netherlands when referring to the entire country.
- Scandinavia refers to Norway and Sweden only; the Nordic countries refer to Norway, Sweden, Denmark, Finland and Iceland.

Check the meaning of the usage carefully.

### TIP

**Contractions give writing a friendly and conversational tone. They’re appropriate for some letters and articles, but avoid them when writing more formal communications.**



## Currencies

In international communications, use figures in US dollars whenever possible — almost all readers will be able to translate your figures into an amount they understand.

If it is helpful to refer to other currencies, be precise about the currency you are referring to by using the International Organization for Standardization (ISO) codes found at [www.xe.com/iso4217.htm](http://www.xe.com/iso4217.htm). On first reference, spell out the currency [e.g. Algerian dinars (DZD)] and use only the code on subsequent references (e.g. DZD10 million).

No space is required between the currency code and the amount:

- US\$1.5 million.

## Dates

Write dates in the following ways:

- 1 May 2022
- 1–5 May 2022
- Monday 1 May 2022
- 2020–22 (not 2020–2022)
- the 2020s

Consistency is important; please use the same style if writing a number of dates. Please note that the use of “st”, “nd”, “rd” and “th” is not required. Commas are not required even if you are using a day and date.

## Ellipses

Ellipses consist of three full stops (periods) in a row. Use them to show omission of a word or words from a text or quotation:

- “The best executive ... has sense enough to pick good men to do what he wants done, and self-restraint to keep from meddling with them while they do it.” — Theodore Roosevelt

Put spaces before the first and after the last stop, but none in between. If you end with an ellipsis do not add a fourth full stop.

## Em dashes

There are two main kinds of dashes and you should take care to use the appropriate one. Use the em dash (—) in text and use the shorter en dash (–) in tables and other charted information. Dashes should be used sparingly and include a space on either side.

1. Use an em dash to set off a series within a phrase:
  - She listed the elements — accuracy, speed, diligence, intelligence — that she wanted in her staff.
2. Use an em dash to provide emphasis:
  - His influence — he was the lead partner on the engagement — was an important part of the outcome.
3. Use an em dash to qualify a word or phrase:
  - He told the team — a group drawn from around the world — that the work was excellent.
4. Use an em dash to summarize:
  - She loved the two main challenges of the position — meeting deadlines and winning clients.
5. Use an em dash to attribute quotes:
  - “Who steals my purse steals trash.” — Shakespeare



## En dashes

An en dash should be the width of the letter “n” in the font you are using.

Use an en dash to indicate inclusiveness:

- 1976–79
- page 1–18

## Exclamation marks

Use an exclamation mark to express a high degree of surprise or other strong emotion. It should be avoided in almost all business writing.

## Full stops (periods)

A full stop or period is an end marker. Use it to mark the end of a sentence.

Use a full stop or period at the end of abbreviations:

- cont.
- fig.
- tel.

Use a full stop or period for Latin short forms:

- e.g. (exempli gratia, for example)
- i.e. (id est, that is)
- etc. (et cetera, and so on)
- et al. (et alii, and others)

**Note:** There is no need to follow e.g. and i.e. with a comma.

Place a full stop inside quotation marks if the quote is a full sentence, but outside if it is only part of a sentence. For clarity, use full stops (periods) with initials: e.g. John F. Kennedy, T.S. Eliot. Avoid using full stops (periods) for abbreviations that use only the initials of a name: e.g. JFK, LBJ.

### TIP

**Short sentences are generally easier to read, understand and remember. So use full stops (periods) often. But also vary your writing by adding some longer sentences — variety creates rhythm, which helps keep people’s attention and interest.**

## Gender

We should avoid gender bias in our writing and use gender neutral and inclusive language in all our communications, except where legally required. It’s also important to understand the nuances of the market you are writing for to ensure your language is authentic and relevant.

Gender is not synonymous with sex. Gender refers to a person’s social identity, while sex refers to biological characteristics.

Transgender is an adjective (e.g. transgender man and transgender woman) that refers to someone whose biology at birth does not match their gender identity. Do not use transgender as a noun or use the term transgendered.

Here are a few pointers:

- Since not everyone falls in the category of “male/man” or “female/woman”, in your writing avoid references to both as inclusive of all people. Consider referring to “a person” or “people”.
- Talk to the individual by using “you”. For example: “You should notify your line or engagement manager in advance of taking annual holiday”.
- Consider using the imperative. For example: “Please notify your line or engagement manager in advance of taking annual holiday”.
- Some individuals use or prefer others to use “they”, “them” and “their” as singular pronouns. This is an acceptable grammatical standard and should be used in any formal or informal documentation if an individual requests it.
- If what you are writing *must* differentiate between men and women, then the terms “men” and “women” are the preferred terminology (as opposed to “male” and “female”). An example would be if you’re referring to statistical data like employment statistics that breaks down the data by gender.

## Hyphens

Use hyphens to join words or parts of words.

1. Generally, you write compound words as one word (e.g. stockbroker, timesheet, weekend, online, email, coordinate, cooperation, worldwide, etc.), but there are exceptions, most of which ensure clarity or help with pronunciation:

- right-of-way
- editor-in-chief
- sit-in
- decision-maker

Use hyphens to underline a connection:

- net-zero targets
- a first-quarter statement
- a full-time position
- cost-of-living increase

**Note:** While you may hyphenate a combination before a noun (as with first quarter, above), you might not hyphenate it after a noun, as it's not acting as a modifier for that noun. For example:

- Our targets will help us reach net zero.
- The statement included the first quarter.
- She works full time.
- This increased the cost of living.

2. Use hyphens to avoid duplicate vowels or tripled consonants:

- pre-empt
- shell-like

3. Use hyphens to clarify numbers with connecting words ending in "y" to other words:

- twenty-one

To write out fractions:

- two-thirds

To combine number-unit adjectives:

- 100-year celebration

## Italics

Use italics to indicate the title of entire published works such as books, periodicals, plays, reports, events and awards:

- *The Cook's Best Friend* is designed to help those with no experience in the kitchen.
- This production of Shakespeare's *The Tempest* has received rave reviews.
- He has won the *Young Italian of the Year Award*.

## Measurements

Use metric measurements. Unit names can be written in full or shortened to their symbols. When written in full, always make the first letter lowercase. Symbols should usually be lowercase, too.

Use a space between numbers when the unit is written in full:

- 25 grams
- 16 kilometers
- 12 percent

Use a space between numbers and the unit symbol:

- 12 cm
- 9 m

You do not need to add an “s” to make a unit symbol plural:

- 25 kg

**Note:** Use “percent” rather than % unless the document is primarily financial in nature.

## Numbers

Spell out whole numbers up to nine, including zero. Use figures for 10 and above. Similarly, spell out first to ninth when they indicate a sequence in time or location and use figures beginning with 10th.

Don’t start sentences with a digit unless you are referring to a calendar year:

- 1998, 2009, 1858

Spell out numbers at the beginning of a sentence:

- Ninety-five graduates were recruited.
- Last year, 95 graduates were recruited.
- 1995 was a very good year for the company.

Spell out numbers in casual expressions:

- two-fold, ten-fold (not 2-fold)
- thanks a million
- he walked a quarter of a mile

Spell out numbers in contracts:

- 26 (twenty-six)
- US\$143 (one hundred and forty-three US dollars)
- 1,155 (one thousand one hundred and fifty-five)

Spell out fractions and amounts less than one using hyphens between the words:

- two-thirds, four-fifths

Use a figure-word combination for values of 1 million or more:

- 2 million people
- \$3 billion (not “three billion dollars”)

Write numbers as figures in reference to ages, votes, dimensions and time of day.

- a 5-year-old boy
- a 5-4 ruling
- he is 6 feet 2 inches tall; 4 centimeters
- 1 p.m.

**When in doubt, follow the number guidelines outlined in the AP Stylebook.**

### TIP

**Remember to check and use the US English spelling of measurements, such as centimeter and kilometer.**

Write numbers as figures when they appear as page numbers or as percentages:

- page 10
- 2 percent

Write numbers as figures for decimal amounts. Decimal amounts are written as figures. Use a full stop or period to indicate decimal amounts. Aside from financial documents where more detail is needed, do not exceed two decimal places.

Use the internationally accepted standards of a full stop for decimal places and commas for hundreds places:

- 1,897,976
- 89.67

Write numbers as figures for large numbers:

- AUD1.9 million
- US\$5.6 billion

## **Nationality, race, ethnicity and Indigenous peoples and communities**

- Whenever possible, be specific about the group, people or community you're referring to, and defer to the community or individual(s) on how they prefer to be identified. In all instances, capitalize the references. For example: Native people(s), First Nations, Tribal peoples, Indigenous people(s), Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples(s), etc.
- People should only be identified by race, color or nationality when it's truly pertinent. Don't presume identities. *Always* check with the person for how they want to be identified.
- Use racial and ethnic identification fairly (i.e. identifying white individuals if people of other races/ethnicities are identified).
- Capitalize the proper names of nationalities, peoples, races, ethnicities and communities (e.g. Australian, Black, Chinese, etc.).

## **Online terms**

Stay consistent with the following:

- e-commerce (not ecommerce)
- e-business (not ebusiness)
- email (not e-mail)
- internet (not Internet)
- intranet (not Intranet)
- metaverse (not Metaverse)
- web (not Web)
- podcast (not pod cast)
- website (not web site or web-site)
- webcast (not web cast or web-cast)
- web page (not webpage)
- home page (not homepage)
- cybersecurity (not cyber security)

"Social media" isn't capitalized unless it comes at the beginning of a sentence. The singular and plural are "social media", but when in the plural form, use the verb "are".

The following guidelines are intended for terms starting with "e-":

- include the dash in relevant terms, such as e-commerce or e-business

However, the term "email" should not include a dash.

- When an "e-term" is part of a proper noun, capitalize the letter after the "e-". For example, "KPMG's e-Commerce Solution Package".
- Avoid beginning a sentence with an "e-term". If this cannot be avoided, capitalize the "e". For example, "E-commerce is becoming increasingly important."
- Avoid overuse of the "e-" term. E-commerce and e-business are real terms. E-country, e-consultant and e-electronics are not.

## Parentheses

Generally it is best to avoid using parentheses. However, here's guidance on using them properly if you must, use parentheses to enclose an explanatory item that is not part of the statement or sentence:

- The study reveals the true cost savings (see table 3).

Use parentheses to enclose numbers or letters that designate items in a series:

- (a) Banking, (b) Energy, (c) Law

Use parentheses to enclose a numerical figure used to confirm a number written out in words:

- Enclosed is an invoice for nine thousand US dollars (US\$9,000).

## Question marks

Use a question mark to express a direct question:

- Was the information sufficient?

## Quotation marks

Use quotation marks to indicate that the words enclosed are the exact words spoken or written by an outside source:

- Jane Beavis said, "Profits will increase again this year."

Use single quotation marks ( ' ' ) to indicate a quote within a quote or to place emphasis on a particular word:

- Mr. Jones said, "When my accountant says, 'It is not the money, but the principle of the matter,' it is the money."

**Note:** The full stop and comma always go inside quotation marks when the quote is a complete sentence and outside when the quote is part of a sentence. The dash, semicolon and question mark go inside quotation marks if they are part of what was said and outside if they apply to the whole sentence. Always capitalize the first word of a quote.

## Semicolons

Use a semicolon to separate a thought or point. It is a stronger separation than a comma, but less than a full stop.

1. Use a semicolon to clarify a series:

- Committees representing tutors working in the areas of information, technology and communications; healthcare and life sciences; and banking and finance held a seminar last month.

**Note:** The semicolon is used before the final "and" in such a series.

2. Use a semicolon to avoid using "and," "but" or "for":

- The proposal was due tomorrow; it was finished today.

## Slashes

A forward slash between words should not have spaces on either side:

- agencies/teams

## Spelling

Globally, the business language of KPMG is US English. KPMG recommends the Merriam-Webster dictionary for US spelling conventions. Exceptions to the Merriam-Webster dictionary for spelling "e-terms" (e.g. email, website etc.) in KPMG communications are detailed in this editorial guide. For more information, please go to [www.m-w.com](http://www.m-w.com).

For national and local communications use the language or languages used by the local member firm.

## Telephone numbers

Use + to indicate that the caller must use an international dialing code in front of the number. Always include the country code. Use spaces rather than hyphens between country codes, area codes and the remainder of the number where appropriate:

- +61 3 9288 6678

## Time

Use the 12-hour clock when writing times:

- 9:30 a.m. to 5:15 p.m.

Use “noon” and “midnight,” not “12 a.m.” or “12 p.m.”

Remember that when writing for an international readership, local times will be different from your own. Note time zone differences and make sure your reader knows what local time you are referring to, especially if you are promoting a future event or anything else that is time-sensitive.

## Title case

Use title case for all proper nouns and KPMG division, function, business unit, service, and industry names. So, if you are referring to Transaction Services within Advisory, write “Transaction Services” rather than “Transaction services.”

All other content should use sentence case. So if — at the beginning of a headline — you want to refer to the general business area of transaction services (not the specific service line within KPMG), only capitalize the “T” in Transaction, just as you would if you were starting a sentence: e.g. “Transaction services market grows in Asia.”

Follow these rules in all areas of online communications, including navigation boxes, links and headlines. So write “About us” rather than “About Us” or “Press office” rather than “Press Office”.

## Trade names

Make sure trade and other protected names are reproduced correctly. Be especially careful to use capital letters where required. Be even more careful to be correct with trade names owned by member firm clients:

- Hoover
- biro XBiro

## URLs

For uniform resource locators (URLs), otherwise known as web addresses, use the following guidelines.

With standard websites, use the address and drop the “www.” prefix:

- kpmg.com

With non-standard sites, provide the full address needed to access the site:

- https://www.moneyboxx2010.com

If you need to separate a web address because of line length, choose a logical place to do so. Don’t insert a hyphen within a URL to break a line. If “.com” ends a sentence, put a full stop after it.



## Content risk management

Everyone at KPMG must act and communicate in a way that protects our reputation and the equity we have built in our brand.

We influence perceptions of our brand through the way we behave — inside and outside the office — and the way we communicate. KPMG has a dedicated Global Marketing Compliance (GMC) team and policies to help you get it right when it comes to protecting our brand. These policies specifically define how we can protect our brand in our marketing and communications.

The policies include helpful guidance on areas such as:

- key words and phrases we cannot use in specific situations for legal and regulatory reasons
- legal requirements related to copyrights, disclaimers, independence and privacy

For more information on GMC policies, please contact GO-FM Global Marketing Compliance or visit <https://spo-global.kpmg.com/sites/GO-OI-BUS-GCM/SitePages/Global-Marketing-Compliance.aspx>.



# KPMG problematic terms table — June 2022

This table is split into two sections:

- The first part lists terms and phrases that **are or may be problematic** when describing KPMG International Limited (KPMG International) and its related entities; the KPMG global organization; KPMG firms and the services they offer; and professionals who work for KPMG firms.
- The second part lists terms and phrases **that need substantiation**, including guarantees, promissory language and claims. These terms **are not prohibited** from use but must be supportable and appear in the proper context when referring to KPMG International and its related entities; the KPMG global organization; KPMG firms and the services they offer; and professionals who work for KPMG firms.

Each term or phrase has a list of alternatives and supporting guidance, as well an explanation of the issues these terms or phrases may present. Global Marketing Compliance can help answer your questions regarding the problematic terms and language described below based on your specific project.

In all cases, the context of the specific term(s) needs to be considered. Please refer to the latest edition of the [Global Marketing Compliance Policies](#) for more details.

## Part one — Problematic terms

| Terms                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | Alternatives                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | KPMG firm guidance and rationale                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | KPMG International guidance and rationale                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Terms that imply that KPMG is one global firm: <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• one global firm</li><li>• global firm</li><li>• the firm</li></ul> <b>These terms are always problematic and shall not be used.</b> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• a global organization the KPMG global organization of firms</li><li>• a global organization of professional services firms</li><li>• KPMG firms</li></ul> <b>(Please note:</b> A range of examples of appropriate terms and descriptions may be found in <i>KPMG International’s Annual Corporate Reporting</i> .) | It is critical that KPMG shall not be referred to as “a global firm”.<br><br>KPMG is not one firm.<br><br>A suggestion that KPMG is a global firm is inaccurate and increases litigation risk for KPMG firms and KPMG International Limited and its related entities.<br><br>KPMG firms provide services to clients, not KPMG International or its related entities. | KPMG International Limited ( <b>KPMG International</b> ) is the coordinating entity for the global organization. As a private English company limited by guarantee, it has no clients, no fee-earning staff and generates no revenues.<br><br>Entities related to KPMG International own and license KPMG intellectual property.<br><br>Each KPMG firm is a legally distinct and separate entity and describes itself as such.<br><br>To make an explicit or implicit suggestion that KPMG International undertakes the work of KPMG firms is inaccurate. |

| Terms                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | Alternatives                                                                                                                                                             | KPMG firm guidance and rationale                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | KPMG International guidance and rationale                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |                                                                                                                                                                          | KPMG International Limited is a private English company limited by guarantee and does not provide services to clients. Each KPMG firm is affiliated with KPMG International Limited but is a legally distinct and separate entity and describes itself as such.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | The use of “the firm” or “our firm” when discussing global activity perpetuates this mistaken view of the global organization governance, structure and activities.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• zero audit failure</li> <li>• zero tolerance for audit failure</li> </ul> <p><b>These phrases are always problematic and shall not be used.</b></p>                                                                            |                                                                                                                                                                          | These phrases may not be used as they imply a promise or guarantee of perfection that is not attainable.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             | These phrases may not be used as they imply a promise or guarantee of perfection that is not attainable.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• our clients</li> <li>• we provide services</li> <li>• we generate client revenues</li> </ul> <p><b>The above terms may be problematic, and their use depends on the context. See “guidance and rationale” for details.</b></p> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• firms’ clients, services, revenues</li> <li>• firm clients, services, revenues</li> </ul> <p>Specify the reference upfront.</p> | <p>Having clients, providing services to clients, or generating revenues from client service activities are all undertaken by KPMG firms, rather than KPMG International Limited or its related entities.</p> <p>Care should be taken when communicating about the relationship between any KPMG firm and its clients.</p> <p>A KPMG firm may refer to its clients as “our clients” and state that “we provide services to” and “we generate client revenues” from those clients.</p> <p>Where a KPMG firm wishes to refer to the clients of the wider KPMG organization in aggregate, the services provided to those clients and the revenue generated, it should use the alternative wording suggested in the column on the left. The reason for this is to avoid an explicit or implicit suggestion that KPMG is “a global firm” (see above).</p> | <p>It is acceptable to use “we,” “our” and “us,” including in the context of “our clients” generally on KPMG International copyrighted materials as long as the “We/Us/ Our” disclaimer is reflected on the document as well.</p> <p>However, when a relationship with a particular client, alliance or third-party stakeholder is referenced, the specific KPMG firm, firms or global organization owning that relationship must also be identified.</p> <p>Where there is uncertainty over who these terms refer to — third parties, society, nations or companies other than KPMG International Limited or its related entities — the disclaimer cannot be used and the language must be amended to ensure clarity of meaning.</p> <p>Additionally, where space does not permit the use of the disclaimer (memes, social media posts, small space ads, etc.) or in cases where the content owners do not want to use it, the language will still need to be clarified to avoid ambiguous language or implied global firm references.</p> |

| Terms | Alternatives | KPMG firm guidance and rationale                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | KPMG International guidance and rationale |
|-------|--------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|
|       |              | <p>Another approach is to lead with the name of the global practice if it is defined within the context of the KPMG firms providing the services/professionals.</p> <p>For example, the opening paragraph describing International Executive Services provided by KPMG firms may say: “KPMG’s International Executive Services practice provides a wide range of services to KPMG firms’ clients.”</p> <p>Where the “practice” is clarified upfront, subsequent mentions of “KPMG”, “we”, “us” and “our” may then be used if referring to the “practice” area. However, where it remains unclear or references to entities are mixed or if the term is specific to a global practice, KPMG International Limited, its related entities, or a KPMG firm, then all references to KPMG should be clearly defined.</p> <p>This issue may also occur when writing under a KPMG firm copyright, e.g. when listing the clients of more than one firm in a proposal or talkbook. In these cases, the issue can usually be resolved by a lead-in sentence that says, “KPMG firms provide services to...” or the like.</p> |                                           |

| Terms                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           | Alternatives                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            | Guidance and rationale                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>alliance</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>teaming with</li> <li>joining forces with</li> <li>working with</li> <li>collaborating with</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                           | <p>The term “alliance” may only be used where KPMG International Limited, its related entities, or KPMG firms have agreed a formalized relationship with an independent third party.</p> <p>KPMG firms shall avoid creating the impression of a legal partnership in alliance relationships.</p> <p>While alliances may refer to KPMG as their “partner,” we should not reciprocate. In KPMG content, alliances parties should not be referred to as “partners,” and the relationship shall not be described as a “partnership.” KPMG firms should use “alliance,” “alliance partner” or “alliance partnership.”</p> <p>See <b>Section 4.6</b> of the GMC policies for more details.</p>                                                                                     |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Partnership</li> <li>Joint venture</li> <li>Other terms/phrases that infer a legal relationship with a third party that may not be accurate</li> </ul> <p><b>The above terms may be problematic, and their use depends on the context. See “guidance and rationale” for details.</b></p> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>teaming with</li> <li>joining forces with</li> <li>working with</li> <li>collaborating with</li> <li>the use of “journey partner” is permissible in a non-audit context where it is clear within the document or communication that there is <b>no legal partnership</b> existing between the parties</li> </ul> | <p>It is important that any such terms are used accurately. If they are used inaccurately, they may be a source of potential liability and may be viewed as an actual or perceived threat to KPMG’s independence.</p> <p>These terms may be used when such a relationship exists under the terms of a written contract (see Section 4.6 and Appendix 7 of the GMC policies) or when they accurately describe the relationship.</p> <p>KPMG may use third-party descriptions of awards, certifications and statuses, but only with a clear context of origin. For example: Oracle named KPMG as their “2019 Partner of the Year”.</p> <p>We should not refer to awards and certifications without connecting the terms back to the award owner.</p>                           |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>solution*</li> <li>strategy*</li> </ul> <p>*When referring to Audit and Attestation services.</p> <p><b>The above terms may be problematic, and their use depends on the context. See “guidance and rationale” for details.</b></p>                                                      | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>approach</li> <li>methodology</li> <li>technology tool</li> <li>technology planning</li> <li>software application</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                     | <p>The term “solution” must not be used to describe Audit and Attestation services, as it may suggest results that cannot be delivered. Additionally, it could be construed as a threat to independence by implying that a KPMG firm is acting as management.</p> <p>“Solution” may be used in describing a software application and technology tool.</p> <p>“Strategy” can be problematic when describing some Audit and Attestation services, as it may suggest a KPMG firm is acting as management.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>solution*</li> <li>strategy*</li> </ul> <p>*When referring to Tax and Advisory services.</p> <p><b>The above terms may be problematic, and their use depends on the context. See “guidance and rationale” for details.</b></p>                                                           | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>approach</li> <li>methodology</li> <li>technology tool</li> <li>planning</li> <li>software application</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                | <p>Care should be taken when using the term “solution” in relation to Tax and Advisory services. Again, the issue is whether the term “solution” may imply a result that cannot be delivered. This will depend on the nature of the service being provided.</p> <p>In terms of Tax, the term “strategy” has taken on a negative connotation in some marketplaces and is to be avoided where that is the case. The decision on whether to use the term should be taken by the local Tax practice and advice should be sought from professional practice, Quality &amp; Risk Management and (where available) the office of general counsel.</p> <p>The term “strategy” may be appropriate in Restructuring, where a KPMG firm is managing a business through liquidation.</p> |



# Part two — Terms that require substantiation

KPMG content must avoid language that makes claims or representations that **might potentially be false, misleading or misunderstood**.

Claims regarding products and services provided by KPMG firms **must be factual, accurate and independently substantiated**. They may not create unjustifiable or unfair expectations of results or contain guarantees of client results.

| Terms                                                                                 | Alternatives                                                                                                  | Guidance and rationale                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>world-class</li></ul>                           | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>a leading</li><li>one of the leading</li></ul>                          | A term such as “world-class” should only be used where it is accurate. If a particular service or product is not “world-class,” it may increase the risk of litigation, as a plaintiff may claim that you have promised that a service or product would be of a particular standard that you have not delivered.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>innovative</li><li>innovate</li></ul>           | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>enhanced methodology</li><li>leading tool</li><li>progressive</li></ul> | <p>In Audit and Tax services, these terms can be problematic and should be carefully considered before use. Consultation with professional practice, Quality &amp; Risk Management and (where available) the office of general counsel should take place.</p> <p>For example, referring to “innovative tax solutions” or an “innovative approach to audit” may suggest an inappropriate approach that is out of step with KPMG’s ethical approach to Tax and Audit services, and inconsistent with our brand and Values.</p> <p>These terms may be used in Advisory services where the services are not of an attestation nature.</p> |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>integrated</li><li>integrate</li></ul>          | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>combined</li><li>including</li><li>coordinated</li></ul>                | <p>In the context of referring to a multidisciplinary team of KPMG professionals, the phrase “integrated team” is appropriate.</p> <p>However, KPMG teams should not be “integrated” in Audit or other situations requiring independence with those of the client, as that may be viewed as a real or perceived impairment to independence.</p> <p>Care should be taken to avoid references that might imply KPMG professionals are acting as management in Audit or Tax</p>                                                                                                                                                          |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>maximum assurance</li></ul>                     | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>rigorous methodology</li><li>tested processes</li></ul>                 | The term “maximum assurance” shall not be used externally given its promissory nature. Careful consideration should be given in internal use.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>proven</li></ul>                                | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>well-established</li><li>tested</li></ul>                               | The term “proven” should be substantiated. Otherwise, it may lead to unjustified expectations.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>state of the art</li><li>leading edge</li></ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>a leading</li><li>one of the leading</li></ul>                          | The terms “state of the art” and “leading edge” should be substantiated. Otherwise, they may lead to unjustified expectations.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• ensure</li> <li>• insure</li> <li>• assure</li> <li>• maximize</li> <li>• minimize</li> <li>• optimize</li> <li>• will</li> <li>• managing ____ for a client benefit</li> </ul>                                                                                         | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• foster</li> <li>• determine</li> <li>• enhance help</li> <li>• can</li> <li>• may</li> <li>• aim to</li> <li>• analyze</li> <li>• assist</li> <li>• assess attest</li> <li>• report</li> <li>• potential benefit</li> </ul> | <p>These terms can imply a guarantee when, in fact, in many service offerings, such a guarantee is not possible.</p> <p>In most service offerings, we can advise management, but it is their choice to use the advice or not and they control implementation.</p> |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• all</li> <li>• best</li> <li>• most</li> <li>• each</li> <li>• every</li> <li>• first</li> <li>• largest</li> <li>• superior</li> <li>• preeminent</li> <li>• unique</li> <li>• highest quality</li> <li>• optimum</li> <li>• unparalleled</li> <li>• always</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• one of the leading</li> <li>• among the best</li> <li>• strive for the highest quality</li> <li>• among the largest</li> </ul>                                                                                              | <p>If these terms or phrases can be substantiated, they may be used.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• comprehensive</li> <li>• end-to-end</li> <li>• one-stop-shop</li> <li>• seamless</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                             | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• a range of services</li> <li>• wide-ranging</li> <li>• thorough</li> <li>• broad</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                 |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• best practice</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• leading practice</li> <li>• define/attribute best practice: e.g. industry best practice</li> <li>• best practice as defined by (name of publication)</li> </ul>                                                             | <p>A claim that something is a “best practice” may be used if it can be substantiated.</p>                                                                                                                                                                        |



# Contact us

## Functional mailbox

[go-fmglobalbrandmngm@kpmg.com](mailto:go-fmglobalbrandmngm@kpmg.com)

## Brand Central

<https://www.brand.kworld.kpmg.com>

For KPMG users

<https://www.brand.kpmg.com>

For third-party vendors

## [kpmg.com/socialmedia](https://kpmg.com/socialmedia)



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